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A cura di Chiara Barbieri
Pier Paolo Peruccio, Dora Souza Dias

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# Saggi

# Organising design in a changing environment

## DOGA and the Norwegian design organisations

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This article presents a history of the Norwegian design organisation DOGA (Design and Architecture Norway) and the organisations that preceded it. Although DOGA was founded as recently as 2014, it is the result of a long history of relocations, reorganisations and mergers which ultimately lead back to Foreningen Brukskunst (the Applied Art Association), founded in 1918.

Following advances in organisational studies, we chose to view organisations as processes rather than things, with dynamic and changeable, rather than enduring and stable identities (Gioia, Patvardhan, Hamilton, & Corley, 2013, pp. 123-4, 180). This provides a way of working through issues of continuity and discontinuity encountered by historians and organisation theorists alike. Both historians and organisations themselves may choose to emphasise continuity.

*The Bloomsbury Encyclopedia of Design* describes DOGA as "an amalgamation" of Norsk Form (Norwegian Form) and the Norwegian Design Council, with Norsk Form in turn being "the final incarnation of the Landsforbundet Norsk Brukskonst [sic.] of 1918" (Hagströmer, 2016, p. 466). The Norwegian Design Council similarly listed the Council of Industrial Design and the Norwegian Design Centre as predecessors on its website (Norsk Designråd, n.d.). Other sources may resist such broad sweep approaches in fear of glossing over significant changes, or because they want to communicate newness rather than what Gioia et al. term "identity continuity" (2013, pp. 164-5). The following attempts to strike a balance

between continuity and discontinuity, taking the view that both inform the evolving identities of an organisation.

In our analysis, we focus on three pillars, each of which contributes to a dynamic process of identity definition and expression:

*Organisation:* This pillar refers to factors such as how the organisation is structured, an organisation's members, its stated purpose and its source of funding. Although they build upon each other, the organisations discussed vary greatly in their structure, operation and *raison d'être* — from societies with an open membership financed by fees and donations in the case of Foreningen Brukskunst to DOGA's current status as a small government-funded national policy instrument charged with increasing private and public sector innovation through design and architecture (DOGA, n.d.a).

*Location:* This pillar refers to meaningful aspects of the organisation's geographical location, such as its proximity to other institutions and its intended accessibility to certain categories of visitor or collaborator. It also refers to the building's facilities and spatial features, factors which reflect the organisation's activities and contribute to its outward-facing image. In this we follow Liu & Grey, who state that "[b]uildings and other spatial features of organisation are highly significant ways in which history is embodied, understood and deployed in order to answer the question of 'who we are as an organisation'" (2018, p. 641).

*The concept of design:* Design has undergone profound change in the roughly one hundred years covered in this article, changes we will only be able to allude to. Through this pillar we investigate how the changing conceptualisations of what design is and should be have shaped the identity and stated purpose of the design organisations.

The pillars are examined across five periods in time, each of which saw the establishment of a design organisation in a physical space. This approach allows us to explore the external and internal factors contributing to the reciprocal relationship between organisational identity and image, as well as the strategic and political manoeuvring they engage in and are subject to.

## 1930: The permanent exhibition as site of reform and education

The first of DOGA's antecedents is Foreningen Brukskunst (Applied Art Association), founded in 1918. The term *brukskunst,* used in the

association's title, was a neologism commonly attributed to Harry Fett (1875-1962) and not easily translatable. As Jacob Prytz (1886-1962), the association's chairman from 1920 onward, explained, *brukskunst* described everything from art to humble objects for daily use. It formed part of a democratic and social programme, linking this to the elevation of Norwegian craft and industry (Prytz, 1931, p. 2). The closest English equivalent is probably "applied art" (Fallan, 2017, p. 40).

Unlike the founders of later design organisations, those creating Foreningen Brukskunst were not politicians or industry representatives. Instead, they were what Fallan describes as "a group of enthusiasts" (2017, p. 40). The association's statutes stipulated that its board should consist of representatives from different professions, but membership could be sought by all. A subsidiary organisation open only to practitioners was nevertheless established in 1931 (Fallan, 2017, pp. 53-4). According to Foreningen Brukskunst's programme, it was to pursue three main activities. Firstly, it should promote the creation of "good rational designs" with the aim of forging "immediate and effective" connections between craft, industry and art. Secondly, it was to publish a journal with "a current practical reform programme". Thirdly, exhibitions were to be arranged – continually, if possible (Ask, 2004, p. 170). As the association's first chairman, Harald Aars (1875–1945), explained, its aim was to "elevate public taste" and thereby to teach manufacturers and the wider public "how to see the difference between ugly and beautiful, between good and bad" (1919, pp. 4-7). An important aspect of this improvement in standards was to protect domestic industry against imports, which the association expected would appear in greater volume following the end of the First World War.

Of the three activities, most attention was afforded to the mounting of exhibitions (Gaustad, 1973, unpaginated). The association arranged several temporary exhibitions during its first decade. However, in 1930 it opened a permanent exhibition on the ground floor of the newly erected Kunstnernes Hus (Artists' House). Prytz emphasised the importance of having a permanent presence, which allowed the organisation to enter "a totally new phase of its activities" (1931, p. 3). Not only did "the imposing and beautiful surroundings" of the building, designed by Gudolf Blakstad (1893–1985) and Herman Munthe-Kaas (1890–1977), create a "high quality" setting for the displays. The inclusion of a staffed office also allowed the association to better advise the public and to maintain closer contacts with industry (1931, p. 3).

Through the office, artists were able to submit drawings for distribution to industry or craftspeople. Employment for artists in industry was also arranged. However, in the pages of the journals *Prydkunst* (1929–1931) and *Brukskunst* (1931–1934), the permanent presence was most often referred to as an exhibition space. The items displayed were not created specifically for the exhibition but selected by a jury from the manufacturer's standard range of products. Each was labelled with the manufacturer's name and the retail price. As can be seen from images published in *Prydkunst* (Prytz 1931), most goods were shown in display cabinets, though items like chairs were arranged along the walls. Textiles were hung from the ceiling in the double-height spaces to the front of the building and selected items were arranged in mixed compositions in the centre of the exhibition's larger rooms. Foreningen Brukskunst's permanent presence at Kunstnernes Hus was maintained until the end of the 1950s and was financed through yearly fees paid by the exhibiting manufacturers (Gjessing, 1980, p. 96; Gaustad, 1973, p. 110).

## 1965: The design centre as showroom and professionalisation vehicle

The opening of the Norwegian Design Centre in 1965 saw the introduction of a new terminology to describe the design organisation space. Founded by the Norwegian Export Council and the Federation of Norwegian Industries two years earlier, the Norwegian Design Centre was the local expression of an international ideal which can be traced back to the British Council of Industrial Design's (CoID) Design Centre which opened in London's Haymarket in 1956. Described by CoID as "a new stimulus to trade" and a "national showroom" of "well-designed consumer goods" currently in production, the Design Centre in London was financed jointly by the exhibiting manufacturers and the British government (Council of Industrial Design 1956). In addition to the permanently rotating display, it mounted special exhibitions, acted as an information centre and contained the photographically illustrated Design Index. This multi-functional building was a space for the Design Council to connect with the public and a broad mix of organisations and professionals (Whitworth, 2025a, p. 19). As such, it can be seen as the expression in the field of design of "the centre" as an ideal in contemporaneous British modernist architecture and planning (Darling & Fair, 2023). From these origins, the design centre idea

quickly spread. British-style design centres opened in "virtually every" industrialised country over the following years. Thereby it became "one of the most popular formats used to promote national industrial production" in the period after the Second World War (Serulus 2018, pp. 132-3).

The Norwegian Design Centre fit into this international pattern. Its purpose was "to promote good industrial design of Norwegian industrial products, with the aim of making Norwegian industry more competitive domestically and abroad" (Quoted in Romsaas, 2004, p. 9). Located in the House of Industry and Exports, it commanded over two thousand square meters of exhibition space – enough to advertise as "Europe's largest design centre" (Ask, 2004, pp. 36-37). The building was a brutalist high-rise designed by John Engh (1915–1996), shared also by the Norwegian Export Council and Federation of Norwegian Industries in the House of Industry and Exports. As Fallan observes, the Norwegian Design Centre represented a realignment of design from the cultural to the fiscal sphere, and toward industrial organisations, governmental bodies and export policies (2017, pp. 138-139). This shift must be seen in context of how Scandinavian Design had shown the export potential of designed goods in the 1950s, and the introduction of a more competitive trading environment created by Norway's entry into the European Free Trade Area (EFTA) as a founding member in 1960.

Although formally established by government, the Norwegian Design Centre's agenda was shaped by a group of industrial designers who in 1955 had organised themselves under the name I. D. Norsk Gruppe for Industriell Formgivning (I.D. Norwegian Group of Industrial Designers). Its first chairman Thorbjørn Rygh (1924–2015) received a place on the Norwegian Design Centre's board, which was to consist of two representatives each of the founding organisations, one representative from the Ministry of Industry and Craft, and one practising industrial designer. Although they had used the Norwegian word *formgivning* (literally "form-giving") in their name, the ID-group soon started using the English term *design* to describe their activities. *Formgivning* was considered unsatisfactory because it only described the aesthetic and surface-level aspects of design, whilst the English loanword also referred to planning (Bøe 1963, p. 10; 1969, pp. 10-11). It also tied into international ideals of industrial design, allowing the group to distance themselves from the older notion of *brukskunst* as part of their professionalisation efforts.

When the design centre opened, the intention was for half of its funding to come from government and half from the rental of exhibition space. Instead of having a jury select the products on display, manufacturers could display their goods for a fee. To maintain standards, an Award for Design Excellence (Merket for God Design) was given to products meeting criteria of "good design". Manufacturers could then use this award when advertising their products. However, the scheme proved impracticable and the design centre failed to secure enough income. In 1973 government refused to maintain its support, causing the design centre to close the following year (Romsaas, 2004, pp. 9-10). In its place, a new organisation named the Council for Industrial Design was set up with Rygh as its managing director. The Council for Industrial Design maintained some of the design centre's promotional activities, but in a severely scaled-down capacity. It had no exhibition space, and the Award for Design Excellence was not handed out again until 1984. In 1985 the Council for Industrial Design changed its name to the Norwegian Design Council (Ask, 2004, pp. 49-51).

## 1993: The design and architecture centre as discourse agent

The design centre idea re-emerged in the early 1990s when a Ministry of Culture white paper called for the establishment of an information centre for design and architecture (St. meld. nr. 61 (1991-92), pp. 30, 140). The information centre would be run by a new organisation named Norsk Form (Norwegian Form). The origins of this organisation lay in the old Foreningen Brukskunst, which after previous reorganisations had shed the *brukskunst* term in 1986 to become Landsforbundet Norsk Form (The National Federation of Norwegian Form). Convinced by assurances that their organisation would form "the ideological core" of the new Norsk Form and swayed by the prospect of increased funding from the Ministry of Culture, the members of Landsforbundet Norsk Form in 1992 voted to dissolve their own organisation (Kjørup, 2004, p. 61).

Although there was some continuity, particularly with regard to the promotion of good design and the mounting of exhibitions, Norsk Form proved a very different organisation. It was a small, project-oriented foundation, led initially by architect Peter Butenschøn (b.1944). Whilst operationally independent, its agenda could be defined by government. Funding was issued along with a set of priorities, goals and conditions, and the Ministry of Culture held the power to appoint three of Norsk Form's six

board members, including its chairman and vice-chairman (Kjørup, 2004, p. 81). The influence of national interest organisations representing design professionals was limited to an advisory body, which in 2004 was disbanded in favour of a more informal "creative resource group" (Kjørup, 2004, p. 17).

Norsk Form's aims and foci were largely defined in the white paper on contemporary culture. Here it transpired that the Ministry was primarily concerned with the built environment, which it wanted to improve. This would be done, not by establishing "new norms about ugly and beautiful", but by providing information and encouraging debate around architectural quality (St. meld. nr. 61 (1991-92), p. 136). The white paper gave less attention to design but acknowledged that governmental support was fragmented between ministries and lagged behind that of other Nordic countries (St. meld. nr. 61 (1991-92), pp. 30, 141). Indeed, the aesthetics of the built environment proved to be Norsk Form's main area of focus during Butenschøn's period as managing director which lasted until 2002. This gradually led to discontent amongst some designers who would have liked to see the increased governmental funding be used more to the benefit of their specialisms (Kjørup, 2004, pp. 19-20).

As its statutes declared, Norsk Form addressed the issues outlined above by functioning as 'an interdisciplinary centre of expertise with exhibitions and other information, courses and consultancy for the public, professionals, authorities and educational institutions' (quoted in Kjørup, 2004, p. 16). In 1993, Norsk Form opened the doors to its newly refurbished premises in the historic Kvadraturen area of Oslo. However, although the foundation's statutes had emphasised the importance of exhibitions, the building was ill-suited for this purpose. Its glass-roofed atrium was serviceable if a little small, and other parts of the building suffered from low ceiling heights and poor lighting (Kjørup, 2004, p. 143). Norsk Form nevertheless pressed on with an active exhibition schedule. In accordance with the aim of stimulating debate, many of these sought to problematise notions of taste and quality. Examples include the inaugural *Elg i storm* (Moose in storm) and sociologist Kjetil Rolness' (b.1961) *Vi innreder hjemmet – smaken i hjemmet 1945–1995* (We furnish the home – taste in the home 1945–1995). In other words, the purpose of Norsk Form's exhibitions differed from those previously discussed. Foreningen Brukskunst's intention had been to educate consumers and manufacturers,

whilst simultaneously contributing to an elevation of the whole field of Norwegian design. On the other hand, the exhibitions at the Norwegian Design Centre focused on industrial design products as part of a drive towards industrial design professionalisation and increased national exports.

## 2004: The design and architecture centre as symbol and organisational meeting place

In 2004, Norsk Form moved out of its building in Kvadraturen and into a refurbished electrical substation by the Aker River. The premises, which would be shared with the Norwegian Design Council, were given the official name Norwegian Design and Architecture Centre. However, it was known colloquially and in marketing as DogA — an abbreviation of Design and Architecture. The building was organised as a limited company which was owned by the two foundations. They had separate offices but shared an exhibition space. Indeed, as Norsk Form's new managing director Brit Fougner (b.1946) explained, the prospect of a more suitable exhibition space was an important reason for her organisation's move.

A further reason, which applied to both organisations, was the new building's location in Oslo's then emerging "creative axis" (Heiberg, 2002, p. 16). In the same year as they moved into the DogA building, Norsk Form and the Norwegian Design Council were founders of the organisation Akerselva Innovasjon (Aker River Innovation) alongside the Oslo School of Architecture (AHO), the Oslo National Academy of the Arts (KHiO), BI Norwegian Business School, the University of Oslo and the regional development agency Oslo Teknopol. As described in a white paper on culture and industry, the aim of Akerselva Innovasjon was to strengthen interdisciplinary research and education in art, design, architecture and information technology. By transferring knowledge to industry, it would contribute to innovation (St. Meld. 22. (2004-2005), p. 64). Several of its member institutions were located along the Aker River, one of the earliest parts of Norway to industrialise. With reference to Charles Landry and Franco Bianchini's *The Creative City* (1995) and Richard Florida's *The Rise of the Creative Class* (2002), the white paper explained how similar areas in cities like Glasgow, Newcastle, Barcelona and Bilbao had been turned into creative hubs by investing in cultural institutions. This was heralded as a successful formula for urban regeneration, to the benefit of business, tourism, creatives and other knowledge workers (St. Meld. 22. (2004-2005), p. 19).

The DogA building's interiors were designed by Jensen & Skodvin Architects. They wanted to reveal the building's historical layers, the oldest of which dated back to 1898. The builders were therefore ordered to retain traces of former walls and only to remove loose plaster. Additions were made to appear clearly new and executed using a variety of formal expressions. This process resulted in what Jensen termed a "complex landscape" or "architectural jungle" which could not have been entirely anticipated or specified beforehand (Stokke, 2005, p. 4). An important part of the project was the conversion of the old transformer hall into a five hundred square meter rectangular exhibition space with twelve-meter-high ceilings, filled with natural light streaming from a row of windows along one of the walls (Arnesen, 2005, p. 14). As an exhibition held in 2006 made clear, the DogA building was part of a trend which included international examples like Herzog & de Meuron's Tate Modern (2000) and Lacaton & Vassal's Palais de Tokyo (2002) (Holm, 2006). Like its better-known counterparts, the DogA building was also a symbol which could be used to attract audiences and draw attention to exhibitions, activities and other work carried out by Norsk Form and the Norwegian Design Council.

## 2024: From centre to office space – the design organisation as part of the governmental toolbox

DOGA's hitherto last relocation took place in 2024 when it moved away from the creative axis it had helped establish by the Aker River. The new premises were a set of more anonymous offices located in Nedre Vollgate, a stone's throw from the Norwegian Parliament. As DOGA explained on its website, the move was motivated by profound societal and organisational transformations occurring over the past twenty years (DOGA, 2024). No longer an arena for design promotion, DOGA was now a key player in the national policy implementation system with a focus on innovation.

The first signs of change appeared shortly after Norsk Form and the Norwegian Design Council's co-location in 2004. Changes were made to Norsk Form's mission statement, requiring the organisation to promote design in "a broad societal perspective" (Berg, 2005, p. 4). This prompted a reassessment of the term "design" evidenced, for instance, by an issue of *Bulletin* (no.41, 2005) focusing on its meaning, history and associations. Norsk Form's projects started focusing more on social questions than on

aesthetics and taste. A well-known example is Design Without Borders, which used design as a tool for developmental aid. Launched in 2001 as a collaboration between Norsk Form and furniture designer Peter Opsvik (1939–2024), it soon secured governmental funding from the Norwegian Agency for Development Cooperation (Norad) and the Peace Corps of Norway, thereby becoming part of the official policy system (Skjerven, 2017, pp. 17-21). The State Design Competition, first arranged in 1994 by Norsk Form with the Ministries of Culture, Industry and Energy and Government Administration, similarly took on a more social profile. The 2008 edition of the competition was themed "Design and democracy: Functional and accessible polling stations". Innovativoli, Kadabra Produktdesign and Blueroom Designstudio's holistic and much-publicised winning entry showcased the benefits of service design methods. This led subsequent editions to ask participants for service design approaches to themes like public health (Norsk Form, n.d.).

This shift was in line with international developments within the design community, calling for designers to address "wicked problems" and the subsequent emergence of disciplines like service design and systemic design (Buchanan, 1992; Rittel & Webber, 1973). Norwegian designers were closely involved in these developments. One of the founders of London-based Livework, "the world's first service design agency", was the Norwegian national Lavrans Løvlie (b.1969). Upon opening a branch in Oslo, Løvlie was invited to join the board of the Norwegian Design Council. He served on the board between 2008 and 2014, where he drew upon his experiences of working with the UK Design Council which had financed projects exploring the use of service design in the public sector (Løvlie, 2024, pp. 32-35). As one of the first in the world, AHO had a few years earlier launched a master's programme in service design developed by Professor Simon Clatworthy. During this period, the DogA building served as a meeting space for a "service design cluster"s which brought private and public organisations together with AHO, Norsk Form and the Norwegian Design Council (Moldenæs & Pettersen, 2024, p. 69).

In this context it should be noted that the Norwegian Design Council from the late 1990s had been part of governmental efforts to increase innovation. In 1998 it started cooperating with the Norwegian Industrial and Regional Development Fund, today known as Innovation Norway (Romsaas, 2004, p. 10).

The nature of the cooperation was outlined in a bill titled "Instruments for an Innovative and Creative Business Sector". It described the Norwegian Design Council as part of the national business policy apparatus, the purpose of which was "to contribute towards increased business innovation across the entire country" (Prop. 51 (2002-2003), p. 7). At this stage, the innovation in question pertained to the design and development of new products. However, in 2008 innovation shifted toward services when the Norwegian Design Council launched a Design-driven Innovation Programme known as DIP. As outlined in the Ministry of Trade and Industry white paper "An Innovative and Sustainable Norway", the intention behind the scheme was to encourage companies to utilise user-centred design methods as part of their innovation activities (St. meld. nr. 7 (2008–2009), pp. 48, 65-66).

It was against this backdrop that the Norwegian government in 2013 announced its intention to merge Norsk Form and the Norwegian Design Centre. Initially, it appeared as if the new foundation would broadly work towards the same goals as previously under the name "DogA: Norwegian Centre for Design and Architecture" (Prop. 149 S. (2012-2013), p. 68). However, by 2016 the new foundation had been given the primary objective of promoting "design- and architecture-driven innovation in industry and the public sector". This primary objective was broken down into three secondary ones, which were to "increase competitiveness in industry", "renew the public sector" as well as advise the ministry in matters relating to design and architecture (Nærings- og fiskeridepartementet, 2016). The portfolio of projects was slimmed down and refocused on those promoting innovation, thereby recasting the new foundation as "an arena for skills development" (DOGA, 2018, p. 3). The new-look portfolio also contained a new addition in the form of Stimulab. Following a successful pilot in 2016, this scheme for user-driven innovation through service design for public sector organisations became an important instrument for governmental innovation and digitalisation policy (Meld. St. 30 (2019-2020), p. 55; Ministry of Local Government and Modernisation, 2019, p. 19). Since its introduction, Stimulab's focus has slowly shifted from service design towards systemic design.

The name eventually given to the merged foundation differed subtly but significantly from that first proposed. In 2017 the new name was announced as DOGA: Design and Architecture Norway. As DOGA explained on its website, the new name was meant to convey that

the foundation was now "an organisation to a greater extent than a centre" (Heggestad, 2019). DOGA's new identity as an instrument of public policy, and its shedding of the centre-idea, impacted the choice of premises when the organisation moved in 2024. The location's proximity to Parliament highlights the importance of being close to decision makers, whilst the exhibition space — once so important — was no longer deemed necessary. Indeed, exhibitions were judged ill-suited to communicating with target groups in industry and the public sector (DOGA, 2019, p. 17). On the other hand, the office spaces, which in the DogA building by the Aker River were described as too dark, and less well-resolved than the audience-facing areas (Holm, 2006, p. 37) were now prioritised more highly. This shift from a public-facing to an internal organisational focus was made plain when DOGA, on its website, chose to present its new premises as "offices" (DOGA, n.d.b.).

## Conclusion

Taking a process view, this article has explored the history of DOGA and the design organisations that preceded it, by looking at five significant points in time in relation to three thematic pillars.

It has charted changing understandings of design as a concept, looking at how the broad notion of *brukskunst*, which aligned itself to the work of artists, gave way to a professionalised notion of industrial design as a problem-solving activity, which could contribute to a more competitive and export-oriented manufacturing industry. The foundation of Norsk Form saw architecture and design pulled back into the cultural sphere at a moment when culture played an important role in the gentrification of post-industrial areas – transforming them into creative and innovative hubs. The focus on innovation, but also on design's potential for social change, encouraged a shift away from products to services. Design became an innovation tool to be used for systemic change. We have also considered links between organisational structure, purpose and governmental support. The first design organisations were either open to all, like Foreningen Brukskunst, or in the case of the ID-group only for professionals. Later organisations were not in the same way member organisations. Whilst they received more funding from government, they increasingly came under the control of the ministries. Funding came with a list of goals and priorities reflecting the concerns of the ministry issuing the funding.

Lastly, we have discussed how design organisation spaces have reflected shifts in purpose and outlook. They are arguably therefore particularly well-suited manifestations of organisational continuity and discontinuity. The exhibition space was established as an integral part of the design organisation space when Foreningen Brukskunst established its permanent presence in Kunstnernes Hus. This was confirmed when the notion of the design centre was introduced to Norway in 1965, although the nature and purpose of the exhibitions held at Kunstnernes Hus, the Norwegian Design Centre, Norsk Form and DogA varied according to organisational purpose and conception of design. The relinquishment of the exhibition space along with other aspects of the "centre-idea", like its open and public-facing architecture, is therefore a powerful indication of how significantly DOGA's identity has changed since 2014.

Focusing on organisations as processes with changeable and dynamic identities offers a way of understanding how they can attract new audiences and collaborators whilst also alienating existing ones. A case in point, which shows how the internal organisational identity has developed out of step with the organisational image held in the mind of certain external parties, is DOGA's current relationship with design practitioners. In recent years there has been discontent amongst designers and architects with what they perceive as DOGA's lack of support for their industries. Whilst DOGA explains that promotional activities, like the maintenance of a presence at the Milan Design Week (Salone del Mobile) now sit outside their mandate, designers like Andreas Engesvik (b. 1970) reply that this is precisely the problem. DOGA's mandate should change back to that previously held (Langvad 2025). As a newspaper commentary recently stated: "Is it DOGA's fault? Perhaps not. […] But it should be!" (Brochmann, 2025).

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